

Speed demon: During his spell against Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Mayank Yadav (right) clocked 156.7 kph, the fastest delivery of IPL 2024. (Below) Mayank Yadav and coach Davendra Sharma paying tribute to the late Tarak Sinha. K. MURALIKUMAR &

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Mayank's selection in the Delhi team for the Vijay Hazare tournament in December 2021. "He got wickets (six in two matches — three each against Saurashtra and Haryana) but essentially confirmed his talent."

Sinha's passing two years ago could've derailed Mayank's aspirations, but Sharma was there to support him.

"Ustad Ji was fond of him. He was convinced he was India material, and Mayank realised he had to work hard to attain his goals. The lad was raw, but he was different. He made batters back away, which was uncommon in Delhi cricket," said Sharma.

Recalling Mayank's early days at the Sonnet, Sharma said: "He was amazingly accurate. For a fast bowler, it is difficult to bowl a consistent line, but Mayank was outstanding."

Sharma told Mayank to improve his fitness. His ability to bowl fast was innate. "I just let him be and bowl fast," said Sharma.

The IPL match in Lucknow confirmed Mayank's ability to bowl at 150-plus, and suddenly, the batters looked at him with awe. At 102 for no loss, Punjab was cruising when Mayank put a brake on its chase by taking the wickets of Jonny Bairstow,



Prabhsimran Singh, and Jitesh Sharma. It was a performance that earned Mayank Player of the Match honours on his IPL debut.

"I was not surprised at all," said Sharma. "He belonged to the big league because of his speed and the gift of bringing the ball in. It was the only time for Mayank to make an impression nationally."

The Ranji Trophy debut against Maharashtra in 2022 was a welcome step in his pursuit to play for India, but a hamstring injury halted his progress.

"The injury was a blow. He could not play first-class cricket," Sharma pointed out.

Mayank turned out for Delhi in the Vijay Hazare (10 wickets in five matches) and Syed Mushtaq Ali (seven wickets in six matches) tournaments in 2022. "He worked tirelessly on his fitness. Mayank has a

natural ability to push himself, and I am glad no one asked him to cut down on his pace," said Sharma. In 2023, Mayank finished with five wickets in four matches in the Syed Mushtaq Ali T20 Trophy, seven in five in the Vijay Hazare Trophy, and an impressive 12 in five Deodhar Trophy appearances.

With a classy high-arm action, Mayank is known to attack the off-stump. Most fast bowlers spray the ball to generate speed, but Mayank's strength is his accuracy. "He does not stray, which puts pressure on the batters," noted Sharma.

The 21-year-old is undoubtedly surprised by the praise heaped upon him following his IPL debut, but coaches at the Sonnet Club always knew his potential. "It's not easy to play him consistently on the front foot. The batters are often

